of the three were arrested or brought on trial. Even if Pakistan were to extradite them they would be protected from the death penalty, as in the case of Abu Salem.

The ultra-nationalists do not care to know these facts. They want Afzal hanged. But there are a growing number of Indians who have informed themselves of the real facts and are doing their best to ensure that he is saved from the gallows. They believe that hanging Afzal would be a stigma on Indian democracy.

Afzal has been moved by the growing support and solidarity and now once again hopes for justice. He has sent his petition to the president in which he has said . . .

> . . . records clearly show that I was not involved in the actual attack on the Indian Parliament. I did not murder anyone and I did not injure anyone. I do not think that the attack on Parliament served the cause of the Kashmiri people and I am genuinely sorry for the family members of those who died doing their duty. I feel no personal enmity towards the nine persons killed or the sixteen injured. It is unfortunately the poor and the vulnerable who suffer. Even if no one believes me I can honestly say that I do not justify or rationalize the pain of the children who lost their fathers on that day as I feel the pain of the seven year old son who is living with the nightmare that his father may be hanged any day.

I met Afzal a few days ago. He is now not allowed to go out of his cell and he is deprived of even half an hour of sunshine. The Red Cross is being denied access to him even though they have a right to visit Kashmiri prisoners. But Afzal is full of hope that he will live to see his son grow up. I asked him whether there was anything he needed. His immediate reply was, ‘Books.’ I asked him if there was any particular book he wanted, and he hesitated and rather shyly asked for Noam Chomsky and Arundhati Roy.

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